

Dr. K. Jonathan Klüser

AGENDA SETTING · GOVERNANCE — DIGITAL POLICY · INEQUALITY

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Net Academic Age: 5 Years (Defense: Dec. 2020)

Selected Research Achievements

Beyond Traditional Elites: Influencers' Agenda Setting Powers in the Digital Age

Swiss National Science Foundation

SNSF AMBIZIONE GRANT (CHF 815 000)

2024 – 2028

- Principal Investigator of a four-year research project investigating how social media influencers shape political agendas and public opinion.
- Combines computational methods (computer vision, NLP) with experimental designs to analyze the political impact of non-traditional elites.

Lost in Transmission: Political Responses to Inequality in Advanced Democracies

Cambridge University Press

BOOK CONTRACT

Forthcoming

- Co-authored with Alexander Horn and Leo Ahrens.
- Investigates the "supply-side" puzzle of why democratic preferences for equality rarely translate into redistributive outcomes in 12 advanced democracies.
- Develops the theory of "selective egalitarianism," arguing that parties systematically shield the affluent from redistribution during both program formulation and policy implementation.
- Empirical analysis combines original, granular data on party programs since 1970 with a sequential process analysis of political responses to inequality and the ensuing policy outcomes.

Why Inequalities Persist: Parties' (Non)Responses to Economic Inequality, 1970–2020

American Political Science Review

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLE

2026

- Co-authored with Alexander Horn and Martin Haselmayr.
- Analyzes how political parties respond to rising economic inequality, revealing a disconnect between inequality levels and party platform emphasis.
- DOI: 10.1017/S0003055425100907

From Bureaucratic Capacity to Legislation: How Ministerial Resources Shape Governments' Policy-Making Capabilities

West European Politics

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLE

2023

- Single-authored article.
- Winner of the Gordon Smith and Vincent Wright Memorial Prize 2023.
- Demonstrates how institutional design and capacity building are central to addressing new policy challenges.
- DOI: 10.1080/01402382.2022.2030602

Positions

Visiting Researcher

Paris, France

CEVIPOF SCIENCES Po

February 2026 – July 2026

- Visiting researcher at the Center for Political Research at Sciences Po (CEVIPOF).
- Hosted by Kevin Arcenaux.

SNSF Ambizione Grant Holder

Zurich, Switzerland

UNIVERSITY OF ZURICH – DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Since September 2024

- Principal Investigator for the project *Beyond Traditional Elites: Influencers' Agenda Setting Powers in the Digital Age*, funded by the Swiss National Science Foundation (budget: CHF 815 000).
- Leading a research team investigating digital governance and the political impact of platform architectures.
- Teaching graduate-level courses on research methods and digital policy.

Postdoctoral Researcher

UNIVERSITY OF ZÜRICH – DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Zürich, Switzerland

May 2021 - August 2024

- Conducted advanced research on online communication, platform governance, and agenda-setting using quantitative methods, text-as-data approaches, and modern machine learning techniques. Affiliated with the ERC-funded project *Problem Definition in the Digital Democracy* and the *Digital Democracy Lab*.
- Designed and taught courses for graduate and undergraduate students on, i.a., political agenda-setting and social policy. Furthermore, I organized exams and supervised student projects.
- Provided expert consultancy to a Swiss technology NGO for a multilingual analysis of public perceptions of AI in Swiss media, collaborating with AI industry experts.
- Participated in national and international media appearances and panel discussions as an expert on the social implications of AI and the political power of entertainment figures.
- Organized and co-moderated academic conferences, including the 2024 COPPR@Zürich and the 2022 Digital Democracy Workshop.
- Contributed to departmental activities such as hiring procedures and academic evaluations.

Postdoctoral Researcher

UNIVERSITY OF KONSTANZ – DEPARTMENT OF POLITICS AND PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

Konstanz, Germany

September 2020 - April 2021

- Researched political agenda-setting and responses to inequality as part of the DFG-funded project *Varieties of Egalitarianism*.
- Developed and maintained a comprehensive data processing pipeline integrating expert knowledge, computational text classification, and crowd-coding.
- Presented research findings at international conferences and contributed to joint publications.

Visiting Scholar

DUKE UNIVERSITY – DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Durham, NC, USA

September 2019 - February 2020

- Collaborated with faculty and researchers on institutional policy-making topics.
- Engaged in interdisciplinary academic exchanges and project development.

Ph.D. Candidate

AARHUS UNIVERSITY – DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Aarhus, Denmark

September 2017 - August 2020

- Designed and executed an independent research project on institutional agenda-setting and policymaking in multiparty governments.
- Built a text analysis pipeline combining OCR and supervised machine learning to analyze ministerial policy responsibilities across three European countries.
- Authored peer-reviewed publications (published in EJPR, PSRM, and WEP) and presented findings at international conferences.
- Taught graduate and undergraduate courses on political institutions and policymaking.

Assistant (freelance)

GERMAN ACADEMIC EXCHANGE SERVICE (DAAD)

Konstanz, Germany

October 2016 - June 2017

- Supported the *Leadership for Syria* program, managing administrative tasks and organizing workshops.
- Co-moderated events on democratization and political reform.
- Served as a teaching assistant for three courses on democratization.

Intern

REPRESENTATION OF THE STATE OF BADEN-WÜRTTEMBERG TO THE FEDERAL GOVERNMENT

Berlin, Germany

February 2014 - August 2014

- Drafted weekly legislative reports on federal policy developments for the state government.
- Contributed to policy analysis, focusing on minimum wage legislation and pension reform.
- Assisted in organizing stakeholder events and networking sessions.

Education

Ph.D. in Political Science

AARHUS UNIVERSITY – DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Aarhus, Denmark

September 2017 - December 2020

- Dissertation: *Beyond Portfolios: Bureaucratic Issue Attention in Coalition Governments*.
- Focus: Bureaucratic cooperation and institutional agenda setting in coalition governments.
- Note: Danish universities award the Ph.D. degree without grades.

M.A. in Politics and Public Administration (Double Degree)

UNIVERSITY OF KONSTANZ – DEPARTMENT OF POLITICS AND PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

Konstanz, Germany

April 2015 - September 2017

- Specialized in policy analysis, agenda setting, and quantitative research methods.
- Final grade: excellent (1.1)

M.Sc. in Comparative Social Policy

UNIVERSITY OF OXFORD – DEPARTMENT OF SOCIAL POLICY AND INTERVENTION

Oxford, UK

September 2015 - September 2016

- Focused on pension policy and quantitative methods.
- Final grade: with distinction (ranked 1st out of 32)

Department of Government, Uppsala University

ERASMUS EXCHANGE PROGRAM

Uppsala, Sweden

August 2013 - January 2014

- Coursework in political science and public administration as part of the Erasmus exchange program.

B.A. in Politics and Public Administration

UNIVERSITY OF KONSTANZ – DEPARTMENT OF POLITICS AND PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

Konstanz, Germany

September 2011 - March 2015

- Final grade: excellent (1.3)

Abitur (High School Diploma)

STÄDTISCHES GYMNASIUM OLPE

Olpe, Germany

September 2002 - June 2011

1° de Bachillerato

ESCUELA DE ARTE Y SUPERIOR DE DISEÑO

Segovia, Spain

October 2008 - June 2009

Skills

IT

Programming Languages R, Python

Cloud Computing Slurm, AWS, MS Azure

Databases PostgreSQL, SQLite, MongoDB

GUI Streamlit, Tkinter, PyQt

AI Generative AI, Transformers (text and multimodal), ML (scikit-learn), NLP (nltk, spacy), OCR

RESEARCH TOOLS & TYPE-SETTING

Data Analysis Programs STATA, MS Excel

Survey Tools Qualtrics, Prolific, MTurk

Typesetting L^AT_EX, markdown, Microsoft Word

RESEARCH METHODS

Correlational Analysis Methods	GLM, Factor Analysis, Multilevel Models, Time Series Analysis
Data Visualization	ggplot, matplotlib, plotly
Experiments	Online Experiments, Crowd-Sourcing

LANGUAGE SKILLS

German	speaking	●●●●●	reading	●●●●●	writing	●●●●●
English	speaking	●●●●●	reading	●●●●●	writing	●●●●●
Spanish	speaking	●●●●●	reading	●●●●●	writing	●●●●●
French	speaking	●●●●●	reading	●●●●●	writing	●●●●●
Danish	speaking	●●●●●	reading	●●●●●	writing	●●●●●

Software Development

Instagram Reel Mockup

github.com/klueserthan/instagram-mockup
2024 – 2025

LEAD DEVELOPER

- Developed a fully functional Instagram-like research platform using TypeScript and Python to study user behavior in digital environments.
- Implemented real-time tracking of participant interactions (scrolling, likes, view duration) with high-fidelity video feeds (Reels).
- Designed the infrastructure to support large-scale online experiments with customized content injection.

VIRENA: Virtual Arena for Research and Education

dizh.uzh.ch/virena
2025 – 2027

CO-DEVELOPER

- Co-developing a universal platform simulator for observing real-time interaction between participants and AI agents.
- Funded by the Digitalization Initiative of the Zurich Higher Education Institutions (DIZH).
- Focuses on creating "protected digital arenas" for testing democratic innovations and media literacy.

Honors

EXTERNAL GRANTS

VIRENA: Virtual Arena for Research and Education

[DIZH Founder Call](#)
2025 – 2026

CO-INVESTIGATOR (CHF 150,000)

Developed a simulation platform that replicates realistic social media environments with customizable AI agents (with E. Hoes and F. Gilardi). The project enables researchers to study democratic innovation and media literacy in controlled digital arenas.

Beyond Traditional Elites: Influencers' Agenda Setting Powers

[SNSF Ambizione](#)
2024 – 2028

PRINCIPAL INVESTIGATOR (CHF 815,000)

Investigates how social media influencers shape political agendas and public opinion in the digital age. The project uses computational methods and experimental platform mocks to analyze the impact of non-traditional elites.

Online Communication Consortium

[UniEuropa](#)
2025

CO-INVESTIGATOR (EUR 40,000)

A cross-national collaborative network establishing standardized protocols for measuring digital political communication across Europe (with S. Müller, R. Dassonneville, et al.). The consortium aims to improve data comparability and research transparency in the field.

OTHER GRANTS & AWARDS

2024	Replicating Foundational Online Survey Experiments , 9 000 CHF, with E. Hoes	UZH
2024	Opensource Online Platform Simulator (OOPS) , 30 000 CHF, with E. Hoes and F. Gilardi	UZH
2019	Travel Grant , 30 000 DKK	BSS
2018	Seed Funding , 75 000 DKK	BSS
2017	Aarhus University PhD Fellowship , 1 100 000 DKK	Aarhus University
2017	EUI PhD Scholarship , 60 000 EUR (declined in favour of Aarhus University's PhD Fellowship)	DAAD

BEST PAPER AWARDS & NOMINATIONS

2023	Gordon Smith and Vincent Wright Memorial Prize , From bureaucratic capacity to legislation: how ministerial resources shape governments' policy-making capabilities	West European Politics
2019	Best Paper (runner up) , Beyond Ministerial Portfolios: Investments in Bureaucratic Expertise	CAP Conference
2019	Best Paper Nomination , Ministerial Issue Dominance in Two European Countries	APSA – European Politics and Society

Service to Community

Peer Reviewer, i. a., JOP, EJPR, Political Communication, PSRM, WEP, PSJ, IJC

2026	Referee , Schweizer Jugend Forscht	Zürich, Switzerland
2024	Referee , Gordon Smith and Vincent Wright Memorial Prizes	WEP
2024	Co-Organizer , Conference on Policy Process Research @ Zurich Satellite	Zurich, Switzerland
2022	Digital Democracy Workshop , Session Chair	Zurich, Switzerland
2021	Digital Democracy Workshop , Co-organizer	Zurich, Switzerland

Research Collaborations

2026 - 2028	Democracy and AI , UNA Europa	University College Dublin and Leiden University
2021 - 2025	PRODIGI , ERC-funded project on problem definition in digital democracy	University of Zurich
Since 2021	Digital Democracy Lab , Collaborative research on the impact of digital technology on politics and democracy	International
Since 2020	Varieties of Egalitarianism , DFG-funded research project on social inequality	University of Konstanz
Since 2017	Comparative Agendas Project , International research network on political agenda-setting	International

Conferences, Presentations, and Talks

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

American Political Science Association's Annual Meeting

Vancouver, Canada
September 2025

PRESENTER

- AI-Generated Deepfakes: Impact on Political Figures' Attributed Credibility and Competence
- Beyond Politics: Entertainment Figures as Catalysts for Pro-Social Behavior in Digital Spaces

European Political Science Association Annual Conference

Madrid, Spain
January 2025

PRESENTER

- AI-Generated Deepfakes: Impact on Political Figures' Attributed Credibility and Competence

Swiss Political Science Association Annual Conference

Geneva, Switzerland
January 2025

PRESENTER

- AI-Generated Deepfakes: Impact on Political Figures' Attributed Credibility and Competence

COPPR @ Zurich

PRESENTER

- From Entertainment to Engagement? Celebrities' Political Messaging and Audience Response in the Digital Age

Zurich, Switzerland

April 2024

European Digital Media Observatory

PRESENTER

- (Dis)information for Hire? Dispelling Exaggerated Concerns about Social Media Influencers' Role in Spreading Disinformation

Amsterdam, The Netherlands

February 2024

Digital Democracy Workshop

PRESENTER

- Fashion and Beauty turn to Politics: When do SMI use their voice to rally for political issues?

Zurich, Switzerland

October 2023

European Political Science Association Annual Conference

CO-PRESENTER

- (Dis)information for Hire? A Computational Exploration of the Extent to which Social Media Influencers Spread or Combat Disinformation

Glasgow, Scotland

June 2023

American Political Science Association's Annual Meeting

PRESENTER

- Venue Making
- Meritocracy and "Wokeness" at the Expense of Economic Equality? Mapping the Left's Concepts of Equality with New Data, 1970-2021

Montreal, Canada

September 2022

ECPR General Conference

PRESENTER

- Colleagues or Adversaries: Ministerial Cooperation across Party Lines

Innsbruck, Austria

August 2022

ICA Conference

CO-PRESENTER

- How Negative Media Coverage Impacts Platform Governance: Evidence from Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube

Paris, France

May 2022

American Political Science Association's Annual Meeting

CO-PRESENTER

- Content Moderation in the Digital Democracy: What's the Problem?

Seattle, USA (online)

September 2021

Comparative Agendas Project Annual Conference

PRESENTER

- Considering the Context: Mapping Differences in Issue Meanings across Parties and Time

Aarhus, Denmark

September 2021

Annual Meeting of the Southern Political Science Association

PRESENTER

- Beyond Ministerial Portfolios: The Allocation of Issue Responsibilities in Coalition Governments

San Juan, Puerto Rico, USA

January 2020

American Political Science Association's Annual Meeting

PRESENTER

- Ministerial Issue Dominance in Four European Countries
- Coalition Government and Collective Choices: Whose Preferences Govern?

Washington, D.C., USA

September 2019

Comparative Agendas Project Annual Conference

PRESENTER

- Do Ministries really have a Natural Habitat? Ministerial issue dominance in four European countries

Budapest, Hungary

May 2019

INVITED TALKS, INTERVIEWS, AND ARTICLES

Audencia Business School

INVITED TALK

- Studying the Influence of Influencers

Paris, France

June 2026

Warwick Business School

INVITED TALK

- VIRENA: Virtual Arena for Research, Education, and Democratic Innovation.

Coventry, United Kingdom

June 2026

Séminaire général, CEVIPOF – Sciences Po

INVITED TALK

- From Posts to Politics: The Influence of Social Media Personalities

Paris, France

April 2026

Round Table – Dutch Parliament

SUBMITTED EXPERTISE

- The role of TikTok in political campaigns.

The Hague, Netherlands

Oct 2025

NL Times

INTERVIEW

- News article about how TikTok gives far-right actors political reach.

The Hague, Netherlands

Oct 2025

Tagesanzeiger

INTERVIEW

- Interview about the political attention in online spaces

Zurich, Switzerland

July 2025

Seminar “Policy, Bureaucracy, and Organization”

SPEAKER

- From Interests to Agencies: How interest groups steer the political agenda
- Contribution to seminar series at the University of Oslo

Oslo, Norway

April 2025

CIS Annual Colloquium

SPEAKER

- Speaker at the 2025 Annual Colloquium of the Center for Comparative and International Studies

Zurich, Switzerland

January 2025

Karl der Grosse

PANELIST

- [Panel discussion](#) on the 2025 German national election, together with Paul Seger (former Swiss ambassador to Germany) and Bettina Ramseier (journalist SRF)

Zurich, Switzerland

February 2025

Radio Energy

INTERVIEW

- Interview about the pending German snap election

Zurich, Switzerland

December 2024

Blick.ch Talkshow on the 2024 US Presidential Election

PANELIST

- Social media in the US presidential election: the influence of pop culture and celebrities

Zurich, Switzerland

November 2024

Radio Energy

INTERVIEW

- Interview about the influence of celebrities on the upcoming US presidential election.

Zurich, Switzerland

October 2024

Karl der Grosse

PANELIST

- [Panel discussion](#) on AI and human rights

Zurich, Switzerland

April 2024

sogar Theater

PANELIST

- [Panel discussion](#) on the topics of artificial intelligence, democracy, and artistic freedom.

Zurich, Switzerland

April 2024

Radio Energy

INTERVIEW

- Interview about the influence of pop idol Taylor Swift on the upcoming US presidential election.

Zurich, Switzerland

Dec 2023

MA LEVEL

Research Design

CLASS INSTRUCTOR

- Foundational MA-level seminar on quantitative research methods and causal inference.

University of Lucerne

Fall 2026

Experimental Survey Methods in the Social Sciences

CLASS INSTRUCTOR

- Block seminar on applied survey methods and online experiments (4 days).

University of Lucerne

Fall 2025

Research Seminar

CLASS INSTRUCTOR

- Research seminar for MA students working on their thesis (2 SWS).
- Student evaluation (scale from 1 to 6): 5.3 (course), 5.6 (instructor)

University of Zurich

Fall 2024

Research Seminar

CLASS INSTRUCTOR

- Research seminar for MA students working on their thesis (2 SWS).
- Student evaluation: NA (insufficient response rate)

University of Zurich

Spring 2024

Capstone Seminar: Algorithmen im schweizerischen politischen Diskurs

Algorithms in the Swiss Political Discourse

CLASS INSTRUCTOR

- Capstone seminar (2 SWS).
- Commissioned by AlgorithmWatch CH
- Co-taught with Fabrizio Gilardi
- Student evaluation: NA (Capstone seminars not evaluated)

University of Zurich

Fall 2021 & Spring 2022

Ruling even when it's not a Match: Coalition Governance

CLASS INSTRUCTOR

- Weekly seminar (3 SWS)
- Student evaluation (scale from 1 to 5): 4.5

Aarhus University

Spring 2019

BA LEVEL

Politische Systeme und Theorien

Political Systems and Theories

LECTURER

- Introductory lecture (4 SWS)
- Topics covered: interest groups, political communication, public policy, moral politics

University of Zurich

Spring 2025

Politische Systeme und Theorien

Political Systems and Theories

LECTURER

- Introductory lecture (4 SWS)
- Topics covered: political communication, moral politics

University of Zurich

Spring 2024

Political Agenda-Setting

CLASS INSTRUCTOR

- Weekly seminar (2 SWS)
- Supervision of BA theses
- 6 ECTS course
- Student Evaluation (scale from 1 to 6): 5.6

University of Zurich

Fall 2023 & Spring 2024

Politische Systeme und Theorien

Political Systems and Theories

LECTURER

- Introductory lecture (4 SWS)
- Topics covered: interest groups, policy cycle, agenda-setting, political communication, digital media
- Student Evaluation (scale from 1 to 6): 4.5 (all lecturers)

University of Zurich

Spring 2023

Political Agenda-Setting

CLASS INSTRUCTOR

- Weekly seminar (2 SWS)
- Supervision of BA theses
- Student Evaluation: NA (insufficient response rate)

University of Zurich

Fall 2022 & Spring 2023

Von Ideen zu Gesetzen: Gestaltung von Sozialpolitik in Europa

From Ideas to Laws: Designing Social Policy in Europe

CLASS INSTRUCTOR

Spring 2022

- Weekly seminar (2 SWS)
- Student Evaluation (scale from 1 to 6): 4.8

University of Zurich

Political Agenda-Setting

CLASS INSTRUCTOR

University of Zurich

Fall 2021 & Spring 2022

- Weekly seminar (2 SWS)
- Supervision of BA theses
- Student Evaluation (scale from 1 to 6): 5.4

Political Institutions: Western States, European Union, and Foreign Policy

CLASS INSTRUCTOR

Aarhus University

Fall 2018

- Weekly seminar (3 SWS)
- Student Evaluation: NA

Einführung in die Policy-Analyse

Introduction to Policy Analysis

TEACHING ASSISTANT

University of Konstanz

Spring 2017

- Weekly tutorial

Analyse und Vergleich Politischer Systeme

Comparative Politics

TEACHING ASSISTANT

University of Konstanz

Fall 2016

- Weekly tutorial

Einführung in die Verwaltungswissenschaft

Introduction to Public Administration

TEACHING ASSISTANT

University of Konstanz

Fall 2012 & Fall 2014

- Weekly tutorial

THESIS SUPERVISION

2024 - 2025 2 MA thesis

2023 - 2024 13 BA theses

2022 - 2023 9 BA theses

2021 - 2022 10 BA theses

TRAINING

Teaching Skills – Systematic Development of Teaching Competence

PARTICIPANT

University of Zurich

2022 & 2023

- Qualification for teaching in higher education
- 7 ECTS course

Reden ist Silber, Zeichnen ist Gold

Drawing Instructive illustrations

PARTICIPANT

University of Zurich

Fall 2022

- Course on how to design instructive illustrations

The Impact of your Voice

PARTICIPANT

University of Zurich

Fall 2022

- Voice training for public speaking

Didactics Training for Class Instructors

PARTICIPANT

- Didactics course for class instructors
- 3 ECTS course

Aarhus University

Spring 2019

TA Training

PARTICIPANT

- Didactics course for teaching assistants
- 3 ECTS course

University of Konstanz

Fall 2014